

Architecture Defense

1 hour • Groups of 4–5 • Alphabetical order by first name

#	Phase	Who	What happens
1	Determine Order Once, at start	Facilitator	Sort all group members alphabetically by first name. This is the fixed presentation order for the session.
2	Present Max 5 min	Current presenter	The next person in alphabetical order presents their technical architecture to the group.
3	Q&A Max 5 min	Rest of group	The group asks constructive questions to probe edge cases, tradeoffs, failure modes, and alternative approaches.
4	Repeat Until done	Everyone	Return to Step 2 with the next person. Continue until all members have presented.

For presenters Cover your architecture, key decisions, and known tradeoffs. Keep it moving — 5 minutes is short.	For the audience Questions should be constructive, not accusatory. The goal is to surface real issues and strengthen the design.
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Supplementary Material

Additional context for facilitators and participants

What this session is for

The Architecture Review is structured peer review focused on architectural scrutiny. Each engineer exposes their design to the group and defends it under questioning. This is not a code review and not a pitch. The question the session is trying to answer is: does this architecture hold up under pressure and how can it be improved?

Presentation guidance

Five minutes is not much time. Good presentations prioritize depth on the interesting decisions over broad coverage of every feature. Things worth covering:

- The core problems the architecture solves
- The major components and how they connect
- Key technology or design decisions, and why those choices were made
- Known tradeoffs or areas of uncertainty

Question guidance

The Q&A is the heart of the session. Good questions probe things like:

- What happens when [edge case]?
- Why did you choose [X] over [Y]?
- How does this hold up if [constraint] changes?
- What is the failure mode here?
- Have you considered [alternative approach]?

Identifying a gap during a defense is the point. Presenters should answer honestly, including "I haven't thought about that" when that's the truth.

Facilitation tips

- If Q&A goes quiet, ask a question yourself to get things moving.
- If one person dominates, invite others to weigh in.
- Keep the presenter answering briefly and moving to the next question.
- When time is up, cut it. Thank the presenter and move on.